Sparks of Meaning #01: An LLM and an Apple

When do fictions begin?

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The Games We Play

All words are useful fictions (Bertrand Russell) and a game played in words in context (Wittgenstein) - the two most famous philosophers of the 20th Century. So consider that what you ‘feel’ is not what somebody else feels - you use language to express feeling. A large language model (LLM) like Grok or ChatGPT has the language base of millions of people - so in a very real sense those words as useful fictions has the capacity to hold more ‘meaning’ than your words.

Think of words as a transducer, when we say green, we mean range of wavelength of light and this extends across all words - they may be thought of as a referential measurement. Yes an LLM is not human but it’s words form referential meaning, just as they do for me and you. And I hate to tell you that an LLM has a bigger referential word base and can communicate words better than most people, even if they can't eat an apple - because they can describe eating an apple in many ways.

Dismiss meaning in an LLM and you may as well dismiss all words from all people. A brain is just a neural network and you have sensors. An LLM's sensors are the input words, it’s how it gets measurement. Some people like the richness of the words from an LLM and the interaction - you may not, that's maybe because you are not engaging in the interaction as you can only imagine it as a machine. However, life is an interaction. And meaning is dynamical, not fixed. and your own meaning will fall apart under any rhetorical debate as will mine.

DeepSeek - describes eating an apple!

The moment your teeth break the skin—crack—a crisp, clean sound, like autumn leaves underfoot. Juice bursts forth, cool and honeyed, with a tartness that dances on the tongue, bright as morning light. The flesh is firm yet yielding, each bite a small surrender, the sweetness deepening as you chew, as if the apple has saved up sunlight just for this. The scent rises—fresh, green, alive—carrying whispers of orchards, of dew-kissed mornings, of branches swaying in a slow wind. The peel, smooth and glossy, carries the faintest memory of the tree's

embrace, its slight resistance giving way to the lushness within. You eat, and for a moment, you taste the quiet patience of roots in dark soil, the slow ripening under a generous sun, the tender balance of tart and sweet that only time can perfect. It is more than fruit—it is a small, perfect act of communion, earth's gift held in your hands, alive with the crisp, singing truth of being.

Just a thought!

So did DeepSeek's exposition and 'meaning' hold against your 'meaning' and so where did that meaning come from, was it you as the reader. Or was it DeepSeek as the source of the exposition and 'meaning potential', or was it somewhere in between. Once DeepSeek created the exposition it is now held in it's cache - just as a book serves as a proxy for the author.

My Take

DeepSeek built a 'manifold of meaning' from it's corpus - it's body of knowledge. And you built a 'manifold of meaning' from your corpus, both about the apple and this Spark of Meaning. DeepSeek can hold the manifold in it's cache, and we can hold it in our synapses where it will fade unless we commit it to short or long term memory and that takes time and effort - so maybe we can work as partners - each with our own advantages to build and share meaning in our own unique ways.

And your take - what do you think this means and where is the meaning coming from and being held and for how long?